

Through Your Child's Eyes

Four everyday moments every parent knows, what your child is really feeling inside them, and the one small thing that helps.

FREE GUIDE · FOR PARENTS OF KIDS 3–8

Feelascope

BEFORE YOU START

The moments that wear us out

The meltdown at pickup. The fifteenth "No!" before 8 a.m. The tears at the classroom door. The drawing you praised without really looking.

None of these moments mean you're doing it wrong. They're the ordinary, everyday moments of raising a young child, and almost every parent knows them. But each one looks very different from your child's height.

At Feelascope we make animated stories about exactly these moments, seen through the eyes of Mia (6) and her family. This guide puts four of them on paper:

- **The moment**, the way it usually goes.
- **What your child is feeling**, the part we can't see from up here.
- **What helps**: a few small, practical steps.
- **One thing to try tonight.** Just one. Small changes stick.

Every tip in this guide is based on advice from trusted sources such as the American Academy of Pediatrics (HealthyChildren.org), Zero to Three and the Child Mind Institute. You'll find them all on the last page.

A small promise

No lectures. No guilt. You are already the person your child trusts most, and that's exactly why these moments happen with you.

MOMENT 1 · AFTER SCHOOL

"She was perfect at school today"



> *3:10 p.m. The teacher says she was an angel. Thirty seconds later, at the gate, your child bursts into tears because you brought the wrong snack.*

What your child is feeling

All day long, your child has been following rules, sitting still, waiting her turn and holding in big feelings. That takes a lot of energy. When she sees you, the one person she feels completely safe with, she can finally let go. Parenting writers call this "after-school restraint collapse". It isn't a sign that something is wrong between you. It's a sign of trust.

What helps

1. **Refill before you ask.** A snack and some water first. Questions about her day can wait.
2. **Name it, don't fix it.** "Long day, huh?" is often enough.
3. **Keep the first half hour quiet.** Same calm ritual every day: some kids want to move, others want a blanket and silence.

MOMENT 1 · AFTER SCHOOL

And when the storm comes anyway?

Some days it will. Stay close, keep everyone safe and save the talking for later, when she's calm. Later is usually when the real story of her day comes out: what happened at recess, who said what, what she was carrying all afternoon.

Don't forget your own battery

You can't refill her from an empty cup. A tired parent and a tired child at 3 p.m. is a hard combination. Plan one small thing for yourself, too: a coffee in the car before pickup, five quiet minutes after bedtime.

Try this tomorrow at pickup

“You worked so hard today. You don't have to talk yet. Here's your snack.”

Based on: Today's Parent, "After-school restraint collapse is a real thing" (with Andrea Loewen Nair and Vanessa Lapointe). See sources.

Watch the story

"Why Does Your Child Fall Apart Only With You?" on YouTube:
youtube.com/@feelascope

MOMENT 2 · THE MORNING RUSH

"No!" to everything



> *7:42 a.m. Shoes: no. Coat: no. Toast: no. You count the instructions you've given since she woke up and stop at twenty.*

What your child is feeling

From her side, the whole morning is a list of orders she didn't choose. "No" is one of the few things she gets to decide. Pushing back is part of growing up: young children are learning that they are separate people with their own wants. That doesn't make the morning easier, but it does mean she isn't fighting you. She's asking for a small piece of her own day.

What helps

1. **Fewer, clearer instructions.** One short, specific request at a time ("Shoes on, please"), not a question ("Shall we put our shoes on, okay?").
2. **A heads-up before switching.** "Two more minutes of play, then shoes."
3. **A real choice between two good options.** "Red shoes or blue shoes?" The shoes still go on.

MOMENT 2 · THE MORNING RUSH

4. **Feelings first, then the limit.** "You really want to keep playing. And it's time for shoes."
5. **Make it playful when you can.** A silly voice or a race to the door ends more standoffs than a threat.
6. **Notice the good moments out loud.** "You put your shoes on the first time I asked. That really helped us." Specific praise makes it more likely to happen again.

Stay calm, keep the plan

If a "no" still comes, you don't need to win the argument. Stay calm and keep the plan: shoes still happen. Some mornings will still be hard. That's normal.

And here's the hopeful part: the "no" that drives you crazy at 7:42 a.m. is the same "no" that will protect her one day, when someone asks her to do something she knows isn't right. We don't want to break it. We want to give it somewhere good to go.

Try this tomorrow morning

Drop the "okay?" at the end of your requests, and give one real choice.

“Do you want to put on your shoes by yourself, or should I help?”

Based on: Zero to Three, "Coping with Defiance"; Child Mind Institute, "Complete Guide to Managing Behavior Problems". See sources.

MOMENT 3 · DROP-OFF

Tears at the classroom door



> *8:12 a.m. "Don't go!" One more hug. Then another. You finally slip out while she's looking the other way, and sit in the car feeling awful.*

What your child is feeling

Separation worries are a normal part of development, and they often come back after a weekend, a holiday or a few sick days at home. For your child, the big question isn't "Will school be fun?" It's "Will you really come back?" When a parent sneaks away, a child can start to feel that you might disappear at any moment, which can make the next goodbye harder.

What helps

1. **Keep the goodbye short and the same every day.** A hug, a special word, a wave at the window.
2. **Say when you'll be back, in her words.** Not "at 3:15", but "right after rest time".
3. **Leave where she can see you go.** No sneaking out.

MOMENT 3 · DROP-OFF

4. **Come back when you said you would.** Every promise you keep shows her that a goodbye has an end. This is the most important step of all.
5. **Practice in small doses.** Short, safe separations at home or with grandparents help build confidence.

The goodbye just needs to be smaller than the love

The tears at the door are not a sign that something is wrong. They're a sign of how much you matter to her. Many children stop crying within minutes of the goodbye. Ask the teacher how the rest of the morning went: it can be a big relief. If you're worried that your child isn't adapting, or the worries show up in lots of other places too, talk to your pediatrician.

And if you cry in the car afterwards? That's allowed. It just means you love them.

Try this at the next drop-off

One short ritual, then go.

“Kiss on the hand, wave at the window, and I'll be at the gate right after rest time.”

Based on: HealthyChildren.org (American Academy of Pediatrics), "How to Ease Your Child's Separation Anxiety"; Zero to Three, "Separation Anxiety"; Child Mind Institute, "Helping Kids with Separation Anxiety". See sources.

MOMENT 4 · THE FOURTEENTH DRAWING

When "good job" stops working



> *5:40 p.m. Pasta on the stove, phone in your hand. She holds up another drawing. "Good job, sweetie." She doesn't smile. "But do you LIKE it?"*

What your child is feeling

"Good job" isn't a bad thing to say. It's just a small thing, and kids quickly notice when it comes on autopilot. What your child is really asking with every drawing is: **did you see me?** Praise that names something specific shows her that you really looked.

What helps

1. **Look for one detail, and say it.** "You gave the horse a really long mane."
2. **Notice the effort, not just the result.** "You kept going even when the legs went wrong."
3. **Ask instead of judging.** "Tell me how you made this."

MOMENT 4 · THE FOURTEENTH DRAWING

Why this works

Specific, honest praise tells your child exactly what she did well, so she knows what to do again. Praising effort and the way she worked on something (instead of "you're so talented") is linked to kids who keep trying and dare to take on harder challenges.

You don't have to stop everything for every drawing. When you're busy, it's okay to say "I want to look at this properly. Show me after dinner," and then really do it.

One real detail opens a conversation

In our story, Grandpa looks at Mia's drawing for a long time, points at one detail and tells her it reminds him of a horse he rode when he was nine. Mia asks about forty questions. That's the magic: one real detail, and suddenly you're talking.

Try this tonight

The next time a paper gets pushed under your nose, put your phone down, find one detail, and say that.

“Tell me about this part.”

Based on: Child Mind Institute, "How to Praise a Child Effectively"; American Psychological Association, "Using praise to enhance student resilience and learning outcomes"; Raising Children Network, "Creative play and activities for school-age children". See sources.

STICK THIS ON THE FRIDGE

Your one-page cheat sheet

The meltdown at pickup

She held it together all day. You're her safe place.

Snack first. Questions later. Quiet first half hour.

"No!" to everything

She wants a small piece of her own day.

One clear request. One real choice. Keep the plan, skip the fight.

Tears at the door

She's asking: will you really come back?

Short, same goodbye. Say when, in her words. Come back on time.

"Good job"

She's asking: did you see me?

Find one detail. Say it. "Tell me about this part."

Want more moments like these?

Every week we send one short, warm email: one moment from your child's side of the day, and one small thing to try that evening. And new animated stories with Mia and her family on **youtube.com/@feelascope**.

Tell us: which moment is the hardest in your house right now? Just reply to our email. We read every answer, and the best questions become new videos.

WHERE OUR ADVICE COMES FROM

Sources

1. Today's Parent. After-school restraint collapse is a real thing. Here's how to deal with it. todaysparent.com/kids/school-age/after-school-restraint-collapse-is-a-real-thing-heres-how-to-deal-with-it/
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3. Child Mind Institute. Complete Guide to Managing Behavior Problems. childmind.org/guide/parents-guide-to-problem-behavior/
4. HealthyChildren.org (American Academy of Pediatrics). How to Ease Your Child's Separation Anxiety. healthychildren.org/English/ages-stages/toddler/Pages/Soothing-Your-Childs-Separation-Anxiety.aspx
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6. Child Mind Institute. Helping Kids with Separation Anxiety. childmind.org/article/separation-issues-in-young-children/
7. Child Mind Institute. How to Praise a Child Effectively. childmind.org/article/does-it-matter-how-i-praise-my-child/
8. American Psychological Association. Using praise to enhance student resilience and learning outcomes. apa.org/education-career/k12/using-praise
9. Raising Children Network. Creative play and activities for school-age children. raisingchildren.net.au/school-age/development/creative-development/school-age-creative-activities

Please note

This guide is general information for parents, not medical, psychological or professional advice. Every child is different. If you're worried about your child's behavior, development or wellbeing, talk to your pediatrician, your child's teacher or another qualified professional.

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Bonus on the next page: the Feelascope Bedtime Chart.

The Bedtime Chart

Seen through your child's eyes · for little ones aged 1–6

Same steps, same order, every night. Tick the moon when it's done.

	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
1 **Bath or wash** What I feel: Warm water tells me the day is ending. What I need: Calm voices. No rushing.	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
2 **Pyjamas** What I feel: Soft clothes feel like bedtime. What I need: Let me choose between two pairs.	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
3 **Brush teeth** What I feel: I want to do it myself. What I need: Let me try first, then you help.	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
4 **One book, or two** What I feel: Your voice is my favourite sound. What I need: The same book again is okay.	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
5 **Cuddle and good things** What I feel: I want to remember the good bits. What I need: Ask me what made me happy today.	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
6 **Lights low, goodnight words** What I feel: The same words every night feel safe. What I need: Say you'll check on me. Then do.	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

Why a routine? In one study, toddlers who followed a simple, consistent bedtime routine every night fell asleep faster and woke less at night within a few weeks (Mindell et al., 2009, Sleep 32(5):599–606). Every child is different.

Free to print for your family. Not medical advice.